me. He would always tell me to focus on the next two terms, which would form the basis of my actual military service.

The first term drew to an end. Every year, a team of pilots from the Aircrew Examination Board (AEB) visited various flying stations to assess pilots and categorize them. A team of pilots from AEB was scheduled to visit the Air Force Academy Dundigal in May 1995. The entire academy—from the directing to the administrative staff—could be seen gearing up for this visit. The instructor pilots, too, could be seen flying practice sorties, since the AEB team would fly with the instructors. One cadet from each term would be chosen to fly with the AEB pilots. Usually, male cadets would get this opportunity, as it had only been over a year that women had started flying in the Indian Air Force. It never occurred to me in my wildest dreams that I would be made to fly a sortie with the AEB pilots. Two days before the sorties with the AEB were planned, the CFI called me to his office.

'The CO of AEB, Group Captain R. Damodaran, is going to fly a sortie with you after two days. Now gear up and give him a good show.'

His words left me stunned for a moment, but then I managed a 'yes, Sir'. I broke this news to Anuradha and Supreet in the changing room. Both were very happy and wished me luck. But I was scared, since I had had a long break from flying after clearing solo. Others probably overheard our conversation and the news spread through the academy like wildfire. When we went to the cafeteria later that afternoon, many female cadets asked me if I had actually been chosen to fly with the AEB. Nobody could believe what they had heard. When in class, the instructors would call me and ask, 'Why did the CFI choose you? Did the AEB pilots ask for you to fly with them?'

Most of the male instructors had a look on their faces that meant, 'Do you really think you should be there?' All said and done, it was still a male-dominated profession. Most of the male cadets felt like I had stolen this opportunity from them, and I found myself at the receiving end of judgmental stares. Some of the senior instructors were only worried about the reputation of the academy and thought that choosing a female cadet